perception that the Modi government's economic policies benefit the rich (57.7 per cent are in agreement) and not the poor and the middle class. This is the trinity of issues—the alleged political authoritarianism, economic inequalities and social polarisation—that Rahul Gandhi highlighted during his Bharat Jodo Yatra. If the perception sticks, it could impact the BJP's poll prospects unless the party takes corrective action on these counts.

Meanwhile, the BJP hopes to win votes from the poor and economically weaker sections—what it calls the *labharthi* or beneficiary bloc—by reminding them of the raft of welfare schemes the government has launched for their benefit. Particularly the Nal-se-Jal programme to provide potable tap water to every household; this could see the woman voter, irrespective of her caste, creed or community, back Modi to the hilt.

39%

POINTS IS THE GAP BETWEEN NARENDRA MODI AND RAHUL GANDHI AS THE PREFERRED PRIME MINISTERIAL CANDIDATE

In the next year and a half, a chief imperative of the Modi government will be to ensure that all its welfare schemes are efficiently implemented with their benefits reaching the common man. After all, the positive response the Modi government has got in this MOTN for its handling of Covid and the economy could be because of the free rations distributed under the Pradhan Mantri Garib Kalyan Yojana (PMGKY), which has benefited close to 800 million people and cushioned the impact of the rising unemployment figures on account of Covid. Yet, every welfare scheme has a shelf life and living on government handouts is not what the young want to do in perpetuity. What they want is self-esteem and the Modi government must take measures to create employment opportunities for this huge aspirational class this year.

Finally, while there is no talk of a successor to Modi yet, the MOTN continues to project Amit Shah as the logical choice, though Yogi Adityanath has inched closer in recent years. Nitin Gadkari, whose work on developing highway infrastructure in the country has garnered widespread appreciation, is also in the running. But unlike New Zealand prime minister Jacinda Ardern hanging up her boots after a second term, saying, "I no longer have enough in the tank", Modi is not going anywhere yet. He is running on a full tank and he also has the fulsome support and approval of the public, as the MOTN survey shows. ■

Methodology

The INDIA TODAY Mood of the Nation (MOTN) poll was conducted by CVoter, a globally renowned name in the field of socio-economic research, between December 15, 2022, and January 15, 2023, interviewing 35,909 respondents covering all Lok Sabha segments across all states. In addition to these samples, 105,008 interviews from CVoter's regular tracker data between August 16, 2022, and January 15, 2023, were also analysed for the long-term trendline in calculating seat and vote share projections. Thus, the opinion of a total of 140,917 respondents was considered for this MOTN report. The margin of error is +/- 3 per cent at the macro level and +/- 5 per cent at the micro level of reporting with 95 per cent confidence level.

From May 2009 onwards, the CVoter Tracker is carried out each week, 52 waves in a calendar year, in 11 national languages, across all states and UTs in India, with a target sample size of 30,000 each quarter. The average response rate is 55 per cent. Starting January 1, 2019, CVoter has been carrying the tracker on a daily basis, using the rollover sample of seven days for tracker analysis.

All these polls are based on a random probability sample as used in the globally standardised methodology, carried out by trained researchers across all geographic and demographic segments. This survey is based on CATI interviews of adult respondents across all segments. Standard RDD is used to draw random numbers covering all frequency series allocated to all operators across all telecom circles in India. CVoter ensures proper representative analysis by statistically weighing data to make it representative of the local population as per the latest Census figures. The data is weighted to the known census profile, including gender, age, education, income, religion, caste, urban/rural and vote recalls for the last Lok Sabha and Vidhan Sabha elections. For the analytics, CVoter uses its proprietary algorithm to calculate the provincial and regional vote share based on the split-voter phenomenon.

CVoter follows the code of professional ethics and practices drafted by the World Association of Public Opinion Research and the official guidelines on opinion polling as instructed by the Press Council of India. ■